

5.3 Decibels, Frequencies, What?

If you're going to try your hand at editing and splicing and mixing tracks, you need to have the basics right. For starters, you need to know some of the terminology and jargon you will find when editing. Since there are thousands of terms used in this field, we'll just stick to explaining the terms you'll come across when dealing with Audacity.

Amplify: When you change volume levels, you're amplifying the sound. In general sound terms, this could be the act of connecting a musical instrument to an amplifier that can increase the volume by a multitude of levels. In Audacity, amplification increases or decreases the amplitude of the waveform.

Bass: Sounds of lower frequencies are called bass sounds. The word is often mispronounced to sound like "bahs"; the correct pronunciation is "base."

Bass Boost: The Bass Boost effect raises the lower frequencies in a song to add more *thump* to the song.

Compressor: This is an effect you will come across in Audacity. What it does is soften the louder peaks of a song while keeping the softer peaks the same (as seen in the waveform, that is). Thus you get very little variation of loudness in a song. Try it on a song you know well and see the difference. Most often it will ruin a song, and should only be used on parts of a song where a particular instrument is accidentally getting drowned out.

Crackle: In audio, crackle is a sort of noise or distortion heard in tracks—much like the interference that a lot of us have become used to while using our cell phones. It can be best described as the sound that's first emitted from two-way radios (walkie-talkies) when the transmit button is pressed. Obviously, these are much-unwanted noises in audio, and filters need to be used to remove them.